Yet, both Chanakya and Chandragupta were very unlike the other two empire-builders. Chanakya was happy to remain a minister and, according to one version, may have gone back to teaching in Taxila once the empire had been stabilized. [19] In 297 BC, Chandragupta placed his son Bindusara on the throne, gave up all worldly possessions and became a Jain monk. He took the Dakshina Path and travelled down to Sravana Belagola (in Karnataka) and, according to Jain tradition, starved himself to death to cleanse his soul.

The hill on which he spent his last days meditating and fasting is still called Chandragiri in his honour.

The renunciation of power remains a powerful theme in later Indian history. When India became independent in 1947, Mahatma Gandhi refused all positions of power and made way for his protégé Jawaharlal Nehru to become modern India's first prime minister. Civilizations have long memories, both conscious and sub-conscious, and the legendary deeds of ancient heroes can echo down the centuries. We see this in China too where Mao Zedong liked to have himself compared to Qin Shi Huangdi.

The second Mauryan emperor Bindusara ruled from 297 to 272 BC. His reign appears to have been a period of relative calm and consolidation. We have records of how the Mauryan emperor exchanged ambassadors and trade delegations with Alexander's successors in the Middle East. There is a tale that the second emperor, Bindusara, asked Antiochus of Syria for figs, wine and a Greek teacher of rhetoric. Antiochus sent the figs and the wine but refused the last request on grounds that Greek law did not permit the sale of scholars! [20]

There appears to have been a succession struggle on Bindusara's death. The winner of the fratricidal struggle was Ashoka who was crowned in 268 BC. He was not his father's chosen successor but would rule the empire for forty years. In 260 BC, Ashoka would expand the empire for one last time to include Kalinga (roughly modern Orissa). He now ruled the whole subcontinent except for the small kingdoms of the extreme south with whom he had friendly relations. They are mentioned by name: Chola,